

By **Kiran Nadar**

INDIA AS A CULTURE CZARINA

The growing interest in Indian art underscores the need for continued investment and collaboration to keep inspiring each other, driving one another forward

India is a bustling cosmopolis where everything, everywhere, happens all at once. Indians and Indian-origin heroes are thriving not just here but across the global cultural, business and political landscape. India's cultural heritage and legacy is deeply rooted in ancient tradition. It offers an unparalleled opportunity to shape global perceptions and foster creative synergies. India's primacy in the Geographical South is of immense importance in encouraging a cultural exchange with other countries. These collaborations enhance bilateral ties and create opportunities for a more inclusive and equitable world of art.

The Indian art market is currently at its strongest, with auction records being broken for iconic artists like Amrita Sher-Gil, S.H. Raza, Raja Ravi Varma and V.S. Gaitonde. Contemporary art sales are also on the rise, paralleled by a growing global institutional interest in South Asian art. Now more than ever, works by Indian artists are prominently featured in prestigious museums worldwide. I do believe that years of commitment to Indian and South Asian art by institutions, private collectors and foundations are finally seeing results. This is obvious from the number of artists being represented at the 60th Venice Biennale; additionally, institutional exhibitions currently on view that showcase South Asian artists include the Public Art Fund displaying the works of Huma Bhabha in New York, The Museum of Fine Arts, Houston, showcasing Raqib Shaw, and the Yorkshire Sculpture Park's sublime Bharti Kher display among others.

Unlike the Western art market, which has had centuries to evolve, the Indian art market is still relatively young. The culture of living with original artworks is a relatively new concept but is rapidly catching on. The Ministry of Culture and other governmental bodies have supported various cultural festivals, exhibitions, and heritage conservation projects.

The changing landscape of art: Despite these achievements, we can do much more to amplify India's cultural exports and enhance its global standing. In the past few years, the landscape of art has changed drastically in India, with the emergence of new cultural and creative spaces in art, photography and design. What is most worthy of celebration is that there are a number of private organisations, foundations and institutions that have taken it upon themselves to place South Asian art onto the global stage. The Serendipity Arts Festival and Kochi Biennale consistently deliver outstanding showcases. Businessman and philanthropist Sunil Munjal's upcoming BRIJ initiative and institutions like the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre in Mumbai and MAP in Bengaluru, amongst others, are actively contributing to this cause. Additionally, India Art Fair has played a consistent role in bringing together gallerists, curators and collectors from around the world. Most recently, Art Mumbai too has proved its mettle in this space.

These initiatives hint at the inclusion of art in every realm of life. This growing interest reflects a collective recognition of the importance of art in our society and underscores the need for continued investment and collaboration in this realm to keep inspiring each other, driving one another forward.

All of this has encouraged our ambitious plans to build our standalone museum and cultural centre signifying significant strides in this direction. The new location is spread over a prime expanse of land en route to Indira Gandhi In-